



▲ CONTRASTING DOME, BOWL, AND TOWERS OF THE NATIONAL CONGRESS BUILDING

Teatro Colón

Location Buenos Aires, Argentina

Inaugurated in May 1908, with a performance of Italian composer Giuseppe Verdi's *Aida*, Teatro Colón is Buenos Aires's main opera house. The building was initially designed by Italian architect Francesco Tamburini but was later completed by Italian Victor Meano and Belgian Jules Dormal. Sitting right in the heart of the city, the majestic structure is generally Neo-Classical in style—its ordered facade features an array of columns and triangular pediments. However, its character is better described as “eclectic,” as it displays a mixture of architectural motifs. The theater seats 2,478 people (with standing room for another 500) and is renowned for its excellent acoustics. A series of restoration works was completed in 2010.

Church of St. Francis

Location Belo Horizonte, Brazil

This striking church, set by the Pampulha Lake in Belo Horizonte, the state capital of Minas Gerais, is part of a group of buildings—the UNESCO World Heritage Site of the Pampulha Modern Ensemble—that also includes a casino, restaurant, dance hall, and yacht club. The complex was commissioned by the city's then-prefect, Juscelino Kubitschek, in 1940 and was designed by Oscar Niemeyer. It is considered to be one of the first significant interpretations of modernism in Brazil. The church's controversial design features an undulating reinforced concrete roof over a T-shaped plan. The distinctive tiled mural on the northern side depicts scenes from the life of St. Francis by the Brazilian painter Cândido Portinari.

Ministry of Education and Health, Rio de Janeiro

Location Rio de Janeiro, Brazil

Considered to be one of Brazil's most important buildings of the 20th century, the Ministry of Education and Health—also known as the Gustavo Capanema Palace—was the work of a team of avant-garde architects, including Brazilians Lúcio Costa and Oscar Niemeyer and Swiss-French modernist Le Corbusier. Built between 1937 and 1943, the 15-story, concrete office block features a striking grid facade with a distinctive system of movable louvres that provide shade within. The ground level is raised on supporting pillars, or pilotis (see p.193), which gives the building a sense of lightness.

National Congress Building, Brasília

Location Brasília, Brazil

Occupying one of Brasília's most prominent locations, the National Congress Building represents Brazilian Modernism through its geometric shapes and striking composition in glass and concrete. Oscar Niemeyer designed it with a long, flat roof, upon which sit two distinct formations—a dome, placed over the Senate chamber, and a bowl, containing the Chamber of Deputies. A long ramp leads up to the main entrance and a pair of twin towers rises beyond, housing further office spaces. The project was inaugurated in 1960, along with Brazil's new capital city.